

Practice Paper 42 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — The attic “holding its breath”

1 mark for identifying that the attic feels **still** / **suspended** / **undisturbed**; **1 mark** for linking this to the **recent death** — the room has not been touched since Aunt Vivienne died and feels as though it is **waiting** / **paused** in mourning.

Sample answer: The phrase suggests that the attic has been **completely undisturbed** since the funeral; the room feels **paused and tense**, as though it is quietly waiting for something to happen.

Q2. [2] — The mother’s “brisk cheerfulness”

1 mark — The mother uses an **upbeat, businesslike tone** to **close down conversation**.

1 mark — This suggests she is **avoiding something** / does not wish to discuss her sister’s death (or the attic) openly; she uses cheerfulness as a **defence** against difficult feeling.

Q3. [2] — Aunt Vivienne’s “restrained dignity”

1 mark each for any two of:

- There were **no embarrassing souvenirs**.
- There was **no half-finished knitting** (i.e. nothing untidy or incomplete).
- The items were **only books, letters tied with ribbon, and a shoebox of photographs** (quiet, orderly possessions).
- She “sent careful birthday cards and never overstayed at Christmas” (her behaviour in life was equally modest).

Q4. [2] — Handwriting and upbringing

1 mark — It suggests that Aunt Vivienne grew up in a household that valued **formality** / **etiquette** / **traditional standards**.

1 mark — She had been taught that **neat handwriting** was a sign of **respect** and **good character**, suggesting an **old-fashioned, disciplined** upbringing.

Q5. [2] — “I should have closed it then.”

(a) [1]: The short sentence suggests the narrator was **uneasy / guilty / aware of crossing a line** even as she opened the diary; she **recognised** that reading it was wrong but did it anyway.

(b) [1]: Any **one** of:

- “the page was already turning”.
- “the room was very quiet”.
- “the dust hung in the slanting light like something patient”.
- “I read.”

Q6. [3] — Slow unsealing (language question)

1 mark for identifying that the language slows the moment down / makes the act feel **ritualised, ceremonial, or weighted**; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “more slowly than I needed to” — the deliberate slowness suggests **reverence** and the narrator’s awareness that she is doing something **serious**.
- “as though slow unsealing were a kind of permission” — she is **pretending to grant herself the right** to open it; the slowness substitutes for the consent she does not actually have.
- “I held it for a long time” — the delay shows **hesitation** and the **weight** of the decision.
- “the wax along the flap had gone slightly grey with age but was still firmly shut” — the closed wax emphasises that the envelope was **meant to stay sealed**, raising the stakes of opening it.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q7. [2] — “Not unkind” and “protective”

1 mark — Aunt Vivienne was **not trying to harm or expose** her sister; her motives were **gentle and caring**.

1 mark — She wrote the letter **to keep a record safely**, so that the secret would be **preserved without being shared** — an act of **quiet guardianship** rather than gossip.

Q8. [1] — “Breathing”

1 mark: The word **breathing** gives the house a **living, almost human quality**; it suggests the narrator feels she is **not entirely alone** / that the house itself is a **companion** to her thinking. (Also accept: it suggests she has slowed down and become very still, so that she can now hear small sounds.)

Q9. [1] — Evidence of difficulty

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- She “sat with both choices for what must have been an hour”.
- The choice is presented as **two honest choices**, suggesting both have weight.

- The intrusion of her mother’s voice calling about tea contrasts sharply with the seriousness of the decision.

Q10. [2] — “Yet”

1 mark — The word **yet** shows that the narrator has **not closed off the possibility** of telling her mother; the decision is **postponed, not refused**.

1 mark — It suggests she is still **thinking carefully** about timing, and that she **takes the responsibility seriously** — she will act, but only when she is sure.

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **reflective, thoughtful, sobered, weighty, measured**. (Reject: **sad, bitter, angry** — these miss the contemplative quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “Fanciful”

1 mark for understanding that **a decade ago** the idea would have seemed **unrealistic / far-fetched / improbable**.

1 mark for explaining that today it is **unremarkable / normal**, showing that K-pop has moved from an **unlikely cultural curiosity** to a **mainstream global force**.

Q13. [2] — Controlled training system

1 mark each for any two of:

- Trainees are **selected very young**, often at thirteen or fourteen.
- Training lasts **three to seven years**.
- Trainees live in **shared dormitories** under close supervision.
- They take **daily lessons** in vocals, dance, foreign languages and media presentation.
- They are **evaluated and ranked** at quarterly assessments, and may be **released** if they fall short.

Q14. [2] — “Quietly”

1 mark — The word suggests the industry **does not publicise** this cost / that the failure of unsuccessful trainees is **hidden from public view**.

1 mark — It implies the agencies treat these losses as a **routine cost of business**, and may not be **transparent** about how many young people are dropped or how much is spent on them.

Q15. [2] — “Choreography”

1 mark: **Choreography** literally refers to **carefully planned dance movement**; here it suggests fan activity is **deliberately organised and coordinated**, not spontaneous.

1 mark: It implies fandoms operate with **discipline and timing**, working together like a **rehearsed group** to push their idols up the charts.

Q16. [2] — “Unusually two-way”

1 mark each for any two of:

- Idols **livestream to their fans almost daily**.
- Idols **learn the languages** of their largest overseas markets.
- Idols refer to fans by **affectionate group names**.
- Fans, in turn, **coordinate streaming campaigns** and **donate in idols’ names**.

Q17. [2] — “No ordinary workplace would permit”

1 mark — The comparison points out that idols are **on call twenty-four hours a day, monitored physically (gram by gram)**, and **exposed to instant public scrutiny** — conditions a normal employer could not impose.

1 mark — The comparison highlights how **unusually severe** these working conditions are, and

legitimises the writer’s concern about idols’ mental health by framing it as a **labour-rights** issue, not just celebrity gossip.

Q18. [2] — “Soft power” (own words)

1 mark — **Soft power** is the ability of a country to **influence others** not through military or economic force but through **cultural appeal**.

1 mark — In Paragraph 5, this means using **dramas, films, food, cosmetics and music** to make South Korea seem **attractive and friendly** abroad, and so to gain **diplomatic goodwill**.

Reject answers that lift “Korean Wave” or “Hallyu” without rewording.

Q19. [2] — “Pillar”

1 mark — A **pillar** is a **structural support** that helps hold a building up; the word suggests culture is one of the **foundations** on which South Korea’s foreign influence rests.

1 mark — It implies that culture is treated as **equally important** to **trade** and **defence**, and is taken **seriously** as a tool of **national strategy**.

Q20. [1] — Tone of “tightly managed scandals”

1 mark — Any **one** of: **critical, sceptical, wry, dryly ironic**. (Also accept: **measured but pointed**. **Reject**: **bitter, angry**.)

Q21. [2] — Ending on the question of care

1 mark — The ending **shifts the focus from product to people**, reminding the reader that idols are **human beings**, not just commercial assets, and forces the reader to weigh the industry’s success against its human cost.

1 mark — Ending on a **question / open challenge** leaves the issue **unresolved** and **invites the reader to take a position**, which is rhetorically more powerful than a flat conclusion.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

How K-pop achieves its global success (Paragraphs 2, 3, 5):

1. Agencies **select** young trainees and put them through a **long, intensive training system** covering vocals, dance, languages and media.
2. Success depends on **highly organised online fandoms** who coordinate streaming and chart campaigns.
3. Idols build an **unusually close, two-way bond** with fans through **livestreams** and **learning fans’ languages**.
4. The South Korean **government supports the industry** as soft power, subsidising overseas concerts and language programmes.

What costs and limits accompany that success (Paragraphs 4, 6):

5. Idols suffer **higher than average rates of depression and anxiety**.

6. They work under **constant surveillance** and **round-the-clock public scrutiny** that no normal workplace would allow.
7. The **perfection** of K-pop — synchronised dance, glossy production — leaves **little room for artistic awkwardness** or originality.
8. Songs produced **by committee** may travel widely but are **harder to remember** in the long term.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

K-pop achieves its global success by recruiting children into long, intensive training in singing, dance and languages, and by relying on disciplined online fandoms who coordinate chart campaigns. Idols build unusually close bonds with fans, while Seoul backs the industry as soft power. However, idols suffer raised rates of depression under constant surveillance no normal workplace would allow, and the genre’s polished, committee-written perfection leaves little space for the awkward originality on which durable art usually depends.

Length count: 78 words from “K-pop” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —